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Divine Leadership Press

The Publisher's User Guide

Manuscript to marketplace — how the modern press works.

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For authors, imprints, and the small houses that raise them.

A Word from the Press

For a hundred years, our house has done one thing well: put beautiful, well-edited books into the hands of readers who deserve them. What used to take a printing floor now takes a browser tab — but the craft has not changed. This guide walks you through every desk of the modern press: the editor's desk, the audio booth, the pressroom, and the counting house. Read it once and you will know how to move a manuscript from first sentence to KDP-ready file — with an audiobook, an affiliate program, and a paid subscription business attached.

“An author who understands their tools writes twice as much, twice as well.”

The Use Case

Divine Leadership Press is a full-stack writing and publishing workroom for people who intend to publish a book — not one day, but this year. It replaces the ragged chain of Word, Grammarly, Vellum, Descript, Canva, KDP, and PayPal with a single studio.

What the studio does

- **Manuscript intake.** Upload a .docx, .txt, or Google-Docs export; the file is parsed into a clean HTML manuscript you can edit in the browser.
- **Editorial polish.** Claude Sonnet 4.5 tightens, clarifies, and writes back-cover blurbs on demand. A separate copy-edit pass checks the whole manuscript against Chicago / AP / DLP house style.
- **Formatting for print.** One-click PDF export at every KDP trim size (5×8 through 8.5×11), plus a validated ePub for retailers.
- **Audiobook production.** Full-book narration through OpenAI HD voices, or professional narration through an ElevenLabs key — including voice cloning of the author's own voice.
- **Per-chapter audiobook export.** Ships a ZIP of one MP3 per chapter for retailers that require chapter files (KDP Audible, Audiobooks.com).
- **Dictation & voice memos.** Dictate paragraphs directly into the manuscript via OpenAI Whisper; leave audio notes on any paragraph.
- **Cover art intake.** Upload a JPG/PNG/WebP cover, or hand us an image and we'll wrap it as a print-ready PDF for KDP.
- **Writing agent.** A Claude-powered co-author lives in a sidebar. It knows the manuscript, matches the author's voice, and rewrites any selection with **Cmd-K**.
- **Affiliate program.** Every author receives a referral code; signup and MRR commissions accrue automatically and pay out through Stripe Connect.

- **Subscription business.** Two plans (Author Pro \$19/mo, Estate \$49/mo) built on live Stripe subscriptions with a self-service customer portal.

Who it is for

- **Indie authors** shipping their first or fifth book — one workflow, no context-switching between six tools.
- **Ghostwriters and co-authors** collaborating on client manuscripts.
- **Small imprints and church / leadership presses** publishing several books a year without a printing floor.
- **Course creators and executives** turning existing material into leadable books — chapters dictated on a commute, polished in an evening.
- **Speakers and podcasters** repurposing spoken material into audiobooks and printed volumes.

Where It Fits in the Market

The self-publishing market ships more than 2 million titles a year and grows every quarter. The bottleneck is not audience or distribution — Amazon KDP, Lulu, Audible and Draft2Digital already put a finished book on 40+ retailers. The bottleneck is the middle: the messy, tool-fragmented pipeline between a rough manuscript and a retailer-ready file.

Positioning

Tool	Solves	DLP replaces / augments
Word / Google Docs	Draft	Rich editor + AI polish + voice memos
Grammarly / ProWritingAid	Line edit	Full copy-edit pass against Chicago/AP/DLP
Vellum / Atticus	Print format	One-click PDF at 12 KDP trim sizes + ePub
Descript / ElevenLabs	Narration	OpenAI HD + BYO-key ElevenLabs, per-chapter export
Canva / Photoshop	Cover art	Cover upload + auto image-to-PDF for KDP
Amazon Associates	Referral	Native 30% signup + 10% MRR, auto-payout
Stripe direct	Payments	Turnkey subscription + Connect payouts

Go-to-market plays

- **Speaker and coach launch bundle.** Sell the book, the audiobook, and the printed edition as a \$49–99 bundle at events; DLP produces all three from one manuscript.
- **Ghostwriter agency stack.** Ghostwriters manage 8–15 client manuscripts side by side; the AI polish and voice-match agent halve editing rounds.
- **Church, leadership, and legacy imprint.** A pastor or founder's sermon library becomes a five-book collection in one quarter — chapters dictated, agents matched to the founder's voice.
- **Affiliate flywheel.** Every published author is a natural advocate for their tool. 30% signup + 10% MRR sends real cash to referring authors — the marketing budget lives inside the product.

What Ships Today

Manuscript studio

Rich editor with H1/H2 chapter structure, style templates, track-changes toggle, word/character counter, and quick-tip sidebar. Every save is versioned.

File intake

Drag-and-drop .docx / .txt upload. Documents parsed into clean HTML with chapter boundaries preserved.

AI editorial polish (Claude Sonnet 4.5)

Tighten prose, clarify muddy passages, generate blurbs. Full copy-edit pass against Chicago Manual of Style, AP, or DLP house style.

Writing agent

Persistent per-document chat companion plus Cmd-K inline command. 7 voice presets including 'Match my voice' — samples existing chapters.

Export pipeline

PDF at 12 KDP trim sizes (5×8, 5.06×7.81, 5.25×8, 5.5×8.5, 6×9, 6.14×9.21, 6.69×9.61, 7×10, 7.44×9.69, 7.5×9.25, 8×10, 8.5×11) + validated ePub.

Audio studio

OpenAI HD narration for full audiobooks; ElevenLabs premium narration and voice cloning with your own key; per-chapter ZIP export.

Dictation & voice memos

OpenAI Whisper dictation, continuous mode for long-form, and paragraph-anchored voice memos.

Cover art & KDP setup

Cover upload, image-to-PDF conversion for KDP print covers, author/subtitle/description metadata, publication pipeline badges.

Referral & affiliate program

Auto-generated referral codes, live leaderboard, badge tiers, and commission accrual (30% signup + 10% MRR within 60 days).

Live Stripe subscriptions

Author Pro \$19/mo and Estate \$49/mo billed monthly through Stripe Checkout. Self-serve customer portal for cancellations.

Stripe Connect payouts

Affiliates onboard through Stripe Express; the owner's dashboard batch-transfers commissions with one click.

Owner dashboard

Super-admin controls at /admin/affiliate (program settings) and /admin/commissions (payout ledger + auto-pay via Stripe).

Frequently Asked Questions

Q. Is the AI writing my book for me?

A. No. The agent is a co-author, not a ghostwriter. It helps you brainstorm, rewrite a paragraph in your voice, or find the strongest sentence you already wrote. You own every word; the AI never publishes anything on your behalf.

Q. Which retailers can I sell on?

A. Any retailer that accepts a PDF or ePub — that is essentially all of them. Verified pipelines exist for Amazon KDP (paperback + Kindle), Lulu, Draft2Digital, IngramSpark, and Audible / ACX for the audiobook.

Q. Do you take a cut of my book sales?

A. Never. You keep 100% of royalties from KDP, Lulu, etc. DLP is a monthly subscription — the only money you send us is the plan fee.

Q. What are the plans and what's included?

A. **Author Pro — \$19/mo.** Unlimited manuscripts, unlimited writing agent, PDF/ePub at every trim size, OpenAI audiobook, dictation, voice memos, affiliate program. **Estate — \$49/mo.** Adds priority Claude/OpenAI quotas, bulk per-chapter audiobook export, higher payout priority, and early access to new features.

Q. Can I try the writing agent for free?

A. Yes. Free accounts get five agent messages per day (chat + Cmd-K combined). Unused messages don't roll over; the quota resets at midnight UTC. Author Pro removes the cap.

Q. How do the affiliate payouts work?

A. Every author has a referral code. When someone signs up through your link and subscribes, you earn 30% of their first payment and 10% of every renewal for 60 days. Payouts run through Stripe Connect Express directly to your bank.

Q. Do I need my own ElevenLabs / OpenAI account?

A. No. OpenAI HD narration, Whisper dictation, and Claude editing all run on the DLP-managed universal key. ElevenLabs is optional — bring your own key if you want their premium voices or to clone your own.

Q. Is my manuscript private?

A. Yes. Documents are visible only to the author's account. Nothing is shared, sold, or used to train models. The AI features send passages to the model provider (Anthropic / OpenAI) for that single call and no retention beyond that.

Q. What happens to my documents if I cancel?

A. Your manuscripts remain in the account; you keep read-only access. Re-subscribing at any time restores full editing, export, and audio generation.

Q. Does DLP support voice cloning?

A. Yes — through ElevenLabs. Under Audio Studio → ElevenLabs, connect your key and upload a 60-second sample. The cloned voice becomes available to any of your manuscripts.

Q. Can I export a single chapter as an audiobook?

A. Yes. On any document, open Audio Studio → OpenAI, click **Detect chapters** to preview the H1/H2 split, then **Export ZIP**. The archive contains one MP3 per chapter plus a tracklist.

Q. Which trim size should I choose for KDP?

A. For most trade non-fiction and memoir, **6×9** is the standard. Fiction and business books commonly use **5.5×8.5**. Poetry looks best in **5×8**. The full 12-size list is available in the export dialog with KDP-recommended defaults.

Troubleshooting Guide

Symptoms first, remedies second. If none of the fixes resolve the issue, email support with the URL you were on, the exact error text, and a screenshot; we typically reply within one business day.

Symptom · The writing agent won't respond and I see “out of free messages”.

Fix. Free accounts are limited to five agent messages per UTC day. The quota resets at midnight UTC. To remove the limit, subscribe to Author Pro at /billing. If you are already subscribed and still see the lock, sign out and back in — the local cache may be stale.

Symptom · My subscription was charged but /billing still says I'm not subscribed.

Fix. Refresh the page. If the status stays wrong for more than a minute, open the browser console and check whether /api/billing/me returns the correct plan. If it returns active=false with your payment recorded in Stripe, the webhook receipt is stalled — email support with the Stripe payment ID (pi_...).

Symptom · My .docx upload failed with “could not parse file”.

Fix. Ensure the file is a genuine Word .docx, not a renamed .doc or .pages. Very large images inside the manuscript can also cause failures — remove images before uploading and re-add them in the browser editor.

Symptom · PDF export took over a minute and then timed out.

Fix. Extremely long manuscripts (300+ pages with many images) can exceed the export timeout. Export one section at a time, or split the manuscript into two documents. Contact support if you consistently hit this — we can raise the timeout on your account.

Symptom · The audiobook generation errored with “manuscript is too long”.

Fix. The full-book audiobook endpoint caps at about 17,000 words per run. For longer books, use the per-chapter export instead — it splits at H1/H2 headings and processes each chapter individually.

Symptom · Per-chapter audiobook says “only one chapter detected”.

Fix. The splitter uses H1 or H2 headings as chapter boundaries. Open the manuscript, highlight each chapter title, and apply Heading 1 from the formatting toolbar. Save, then try again.

Symptom · Dictation button opens the mic but nothing gets transcribed.

Fix. Grant the browser microphone permission (padlock icon in the address bar). Also make sure your microphone is the default input device. If continuous dictation drops out, disable browser extensions that intercept audio (Loom, Otter, etc.).

Symptom · Cover upload succeeded but the thumbnail doesn't appear.

Fix. Cover images are cached for five minutes. Refresh the page. If it still doesn't appear, ensure the image is under 10 MB and in JPG, PNG, or WebP format.

Symptom · “Payout account not ready” when I try to auto-pay affiliates.

Fix. The affiliate must complete Stripe Express onboarding first — they'll see the “Connect with Stripe” button on their /help page. Also confirm your platform's Stripe Connect is enabled at dashboard.stripe.com/connect.

Symptom · “Stripe Connect is not yet enabled” when an affiliate clicks Connect.

Fix. The platform account owner must enable Connect once at dashboard.stripe.com/connect and complete the platform profile. Once done, affiliate onboarding works with no further code changes.

Symptom · Renewal charge succeeded but the subscription didn't extend.

Fix. Verify the webhook endpoint (dashboard.stripe.com/webhooks) is receiving `invoice.paid` events. If Stripe shows recent 4xx delivery failures for that endpoint, re-copy the `STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET` into `backend/.env` and restart the backend.

Symptom · The editor is stuck on “Saving...”.

Fix. Check the browser console for a red 401 or 502 error. A 401 means your session expired — sign out and back in. A 502 means the backend is momentarily overloaded; wait ten seconds and click Save again.

Symptom · I can't reach /admin/affiliate or /admin/commissions.

Fix. Both pages require super-admin privileges. Only the seeded owner account has them. If you need a second admin, ask the owner to run the seed script with your email.

Getting Help

For questions not covered in this guide, visit the in-app **Help** page from any screen, or click the referral / affiliate section for your unique code and leaderboard standing.

“The press was never the paper. The press was the promise you made to the reader.”

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A century-old imprint, freshly re-set in code.